I’m a design leader who helps organisations build great in-house teams and digital services

James Cook
Bristol, United Kingdom

Selected work on request

Seasoned designer with 20+ years’ experience shaping teams, leading people, improving design operations, and delivering enterprise software systems

hellojames.co.uk, linkedin.com/in/hellojames, adplist.org/mentors/james-cook

Experience

Design Mentor
2021–Pr • global • ADPList

Lead Consultant
2022–24 • SG/AU • Thoughtworks

Design Operations Lead;
User Experience Practice Lead
2017–21 • UK • OVO Energy

User Experience Lead
2015–17 • UK/DE/IN • Springer Nature

Experience Design Senior Consultant;
Experience Design Consultant
2012–15 • UK/SG/IN • Thoughtworks

User Experience Designer
2011–12 • UK • Loco2 (now RailEurope)

User Experience Analyst
2008–10 • UK • Isotrak

Web Developer
2007–08 • UK • Cambridge Assessment

2006–12 **Freelance**
2006–07 **Cyfle/Sequence Digital**
2005–06 **Afanti Media**

Study

Design for Visual Communication PGC
University of the Arts London

Design for Interactive Media BA
University of Wales, Cardiff

Multimedia Product Design HND
Cardiff School of Art & Design

Highlights

- Grew OVO’s practice from 5→50+, shaping teams, ways of working, and culture
- Established Springer Nature’s global UX community and design operations
- Led Design for Singapore Government’s first large-scale agile transformation
- Mentored 200+ people & interviewed 400+ building inclusive design teams
- Taught accessibility at UXThailand 2024 and Singapore GovTech A11y Week

Expertise

- Building and scaling design capability within large organisations
- UX strategy, design operations, and delivery assurance
- Cross-functional leadership across product, design, and engineering
- Leading research, content, and design in complex agile environments
- Embedding quality, accessibility, and scalability into software delivery

Strengths

- Analytical, structured thinking and pragmatic decision making
- Adapting approaches to problem spaces, and helping teams work better
- Helping product, design, and engineering work together more effectively
- Influencing prioritisation and trade-offs to align delivery with user needs
- Facilitating workshops for alignment, inception, and shared understanding
- Hiring, team design, and defining effective ways of working
- Managing and growing designers, and sustaining healthy communities of practice
- Rapid visual thinking to explore ideas, surface gaps, and build shared ownership
- Shaping solution direction, structure, and interaction design
- Collaboration, co-design, and iterative delivery across disciplines
- Guiding teams through organisational and industry change
- Enabling teams through servant leadership

Recognition

2024 & 2025 ADPList Top 100 Mentors
2019 OVO Values Heroes
2016 GovInsider Innovation Awards
2013 Google Global Impact Awards
2006 NESTA Innovate to Educate

People before pixels.